



# metro PLUS

THE HINDU



**This Gandhi accepts GPay:** Meet the living Mahatma of Chennai's Marina Beach **P3**

**KUNCHACKO BOBAN ON HIS LATEST COP ROLE** **P4**

**What makes a restaurant stick around for decades?**  
On the trail of five iconic spots across the city, we realise that uncompromising taste, and steady hands that serve, are the secrets to keep the orders coming in from across generations

## Timeless tables

Nikhil Raghavan

### Tangerine

For nearly a quarter of a century, Tangerine has stood apart in Chennai's dining landscape, offering a blend of fusion continental cuisine and sizzling platters. Founders Manjula and Arun Rao say that when they launched Tangerine, they wanted every dish to be a signature creation. The result is a menu dominated by creatively named steaks and sizzlers that have earned a loyal following over the years. "Most of our menu consists of sizzlers and steaks, whether it is chicken, mutton, or fish," adds Manjula. "That has always

been our strength." During a recent lunch visit, I was presented with several choices. I entrusted the selection to Manjula, who recommended the fillet of fish 'moutarde' (₹720). The dish arrived on a sizzling platter, accompanied by sautéed vegetables. Tender slices of mahi mahi had been marinated with mustard, red chilli flakes, oregano, garlic, and olive oil. Other intriguing dishes on the menu include steak Josephine Baker (₹750), served with a rich mushroom pepper sauce; chicken desiree (₹620), featuring grilled boneless chicken in a spiced honey and lemon sauce; and grilled tenderloin denia, marinated with Mediterranean spices,

mustard, and fresh basil. New dishes are introduced every year before Christmas. Customer feedback plays a crucial role in determining which dishes stay and which are retired. "More than 80% of our guests are repeat customers," says Arun. "Their opinions help shape our menu." After spending 22 years in the corporate world, the Raos took the bold step of turning their passion for food into a profession. Their hands-on involvement remains one of Tangerine's defining characteristics. @Murrays Gate Road, Venus Colony, Alwarpet. ₹1,500 for two.

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## Feasting on words

The second edition of Bookish Buffalo, a collaboration between Braft Publications and The Farm, will explore the making of a cookbook

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The love of the written word has been a constant binding force for many: people living away from home, avid readers, diverse communities, and the like. Blend this love with food, and you have yourself a rather delicious setting. The former is what brought together Rashmi Ruth Devadasan of Chennai-based Braft Publications and Shalini Philip of The Farm, an urban dairy farm and restaurant in the city. The duo recently launched Bookish Buffalo, an initiative that brings together books and food at The Farm. The second edition, titled The Making of a Cookbook, is set to take place on August 1, and is themed on cookbook author Archana Pidathala's works: *Five Morsels of Love* and *Why Cook*. "Archana and I met each other through a story in *The Hindu*, and became friends. We also stock her books at The Farm, and I was also featured in one of the chapters of *Why Cook*. She worked through every recipe meticulously, and this is something we hope to bring to the event," says Shalini. "We've been friends for over a decade, and we share a mutual love for books," says Rashmi, adding how their dream initially was to start a bookstore together. "We had the name ready too, Bookish Buffalo; that is an



**These sessions are more about a one-on-one talk with the author in an approachable setting, which is why they are held outdoors at The Farm. We like the intimacy that is missing in auditoriums**

RASHMI RUTH DEVADASAN,  
Braft Publications

ode to our dairy farm and our bovines," chimes in Shalini. "But the unfortunate truth is that a brick-and-mortar bookstore is not entirely viable for us. It is something you do for the love of books. Which is why we veered in the direction of kickstarting events."

The first edition, Sanikizhamai is for Sleuthing, held last month, had authors D Suresh and AN Balakrishnan who write under the noted pen name Subha. "They are known for their Tamil detective novels, and we had a wonderful session that delved into their writing collaboration that spans decades." "These sessions are more about a one-on-one talk with the author in an approachable setting, which is why they are held outdoors at The Farm. We like the intimacy that is missing in auditoriums," says Rashmi. For Shalini, Bookish Buffalo was an organic extension of their friendship. "Braft has worked with many interesting writers over the years, and their books are niche. Rashmi has

**The plot thickens** A snapshot from Sanikizhamai is for Sleuthing. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

gifted me so many lovely titles; curating these events at The Farm seemed the right fit," she says. At the upcoming event, core points of conversation include the anatomy of a recipe, what it takes to preserve them, how to turn them into a book, and Archana's journey in self-publishing. "I have a sense of panic at the thought of recipes vanishing with people. It is heart-breaking, and I hope these conversations lead to more people preserving the recipes they love," says Shalini. In addition, Archana will read a few recipes from her books at the event, and Shalini will connect the titles with the food being served. At Sanikizhamai is for Sleuthing, for instance, guests were served Tamil tea stall-inspired snacks such as bajjis, bun butter jam, sundal, chicken 65, and rose milk. "For The Making of a Cookbook, I am featuring dishes from *Five Morsels of Love* like alasanda vada (savoury black-eyed pea fritters), kaima vada (spicy mincemeat cutlets), cucumber and chutney sandwiches, borugula talimpu (spicy puffed rice), kobbari mitai (fresh coconut burfi), and coffee custard pudding," adds Shalini. On August 1, from 4pm to 6pm at The Farm, Chennai. ₹850 per person; prior booking is mandatory. To book a spot, call 9176050562.

# TOP THAI BRANDS

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Hotel Paramount

Established in 1989 by K Altaf Hussain, an entrepreneur known for his philanthropy as much as for his business acumen, Hotel Paramount has spent over three decades building a loyal clientele with good food and warm hospitality. At one time, the brand operated several outlets across Chennai, including a well-known branch in Anna Nagar. Over the years, however, the management chose to focus exclusively on its flagship restaurant on Ormes Road, Kilpauk. Today, the legacy is carried forward by Mushahid Hussain, son of the founder. While Hotel Paramount serves a wide range of cuisines, from Indian and Mughlai to Indo-Chinese specialities, it remains best known for a handful of iconic dishes that have stood the test of time. “One of our most highly rated specialities is the paya curry (between ₹360 and ₹600 for portions),” says Mushahid. “Since we have our own meat shop, we are able to source premium-quality paya directly. This allows us to maintain consistency and serve only the best to our customers.” On a recent visit, I decided to revisit this house speciality. Although appams, often considered the ideal accompaniment, are not available during lunch service, the chapatis offered an excellent alternative. Thick, soft and layered, they possessed an almost parotta-like texture that paired beautifully with the rich curry. The paya itself was everything one would hope for — the pieces contained the perfect balance of skin, fat and meat, while the gravy was comforting, almost soup-like in consistency. A chilled glass of fresh lime juice completed the meal, adding a refreshing contrast to the richness of the dish. For many regulars, however, a steaming cup of dum tea remains the classic companion. Regular patrons swear by favourites such as butter chicken, tandoori chicken, mutton salli, chicken and mutton kuruma, chicken 65, signature chilli chicken and the restaurant’s popular biryani. More than 35 years after its founding, Hotel Paramount continues to draw diners not through gimmicks or fleeting food trends, but through honest cooking, generous portions and prices that remain remarkably accessible. @2/5, Ormes Road, near CSI Bain School, Kilpauk. A meal for two costs between ₹600 and ₹800.



SAMCO

Few restaurants can claim a legacy spanning more than six decades and SAMCO is one of them. Their story began in 1962 when three young entrepreneurs – Soopy, Ahmed, and Mohammed – from a small town near Kozhikode in Kerala set out in search of opportunities in the food business. After travelling and exploring neighbouring countries, they eventually arrived in Madras and opened a restaurant that bore the initials of their names: SAMCO. From its humble beginnings, the brand has grown with branches across Teynampet, Velachery, Anna Nagar, Mogappair, and Pallavaram. The flagship outlet at the junction of Eldams Road and Mowbrays Road continues to be the heart of the enterprise. During a recent visit, Mohamed Sinan, the 24-year-old grandson of one of the founders, introduced me to the restaurant’s most celebrated offering – the mutton dum biryani (₹420). The first spoonful revealed fragrant basmati rice, tender pieces of mutton and a subtle sweetness that immediately distinguished it from conventional biryanis. According to Sinan, this delicate sweetness is intentional. While the biryani remains a star attraction, SAMCO’s menu offers several other favourites. The parotta paired with rich butter

PHOTOS: R RAVINDRAN



Timeless tables

CONTINUED FROM  
» PAGE 1

Opal Inn

The story of Chennai’s hospitality industry is intertwined with the journeys of enterprising individuals who arrived from neighbouring states and made the city their home. Among them was PV John, who came from Kerala in 1972 with a vision and a passion for hospitality. That vision eventually took shape as Hotel Ranjith, a name that has become familiar to generations of Chennai residents. Located on the ground floor of the hotel is Opal Inn, a dependable dining destination. Over five decades

later, the restaurant thrives under the stewardship of the family’s third generation, represented by Ranjith John. As ever, Opal Inn has succeeded by staying true to its values of quality, consistency and attentive service; and a menu that offers Chinese, tandoori and Continental dishes. Ranjith says, “We want every guest to enjoy a memorable dining experience, whether they are visiting us for the first time or have been coming here for years.” Among the restaurant’s most popular dishes are Afghani chicken, crab cutlets, fish Malabar and an array of continental classics. Separate chefs manage the

Indian, Chinese, Continental and tandoori kitchens. Having sampled their well-known sizzlers and steaks on previous visits, I opt this time for the jumbo garlic prawns (₹1,190). The dish arrives on a platter featuring six impressively large prawns. Perfectly cooked and wonderfully succulent, the prawns retain their natural sweetness, enhanced by a delicate garlic sauce. The secret, I am told, is a fresh catch delivered by fishermen each morning. Dessert proves equally memorable. The Opal Inn special (₹325) is indulgent with fruits, jelly, caramelised nuts and three varieties of ice cream, finished with a generous drizzle of chocolate sauce. For a lighter option, go for the tender coconut chiller (₹265) that offers a coconut-flavoured soufflé topped with a bright red cherry. It is easy to understand Opal Inn’s timeless legacy. @Hotel Ranjith, Nungambakkam. A meal for two could cost anywhere between ₹800 and ₹3,000.



Nainan’s

For generations of Chennai food lovers, Ninan’s Restaurant has been more than a place to eat. Nestled within the historic YMCA building at Esplanade, opposite the Madras High Court, this 70-year-old-old establishment continues to serve food that evokes nostalgia. On my recent visit, their parottas (₹30) arrived fresh from the tava – soft, flaky, and light, served with a flavourful mutton curry (₹270). The generous portion of curry comfortably paired with two parottas, and an extra helping of gravy was readily available on request. A chilled fresh lime drink completed the meal, providing a refreshing contrast to the flavours. Founded by the late KA Ninan, the restaurant is now managed by the

second and third generations of the family, Alexander Ninan and his son Tarun. Today, they have also introduced popular snacks such as sandwiches, samosas, French fries and cutlets. Stepping into the restaurant feels like entering another era. Thick red-brick walls, graceful arches and soaring ceilings create a unique ambience that modern eateries can scarcely replicate. The heritage structure, built in 1899, remains naturally cool and inviting. No visit to Ninan’s is complete without dessert. Their legendary caramel custard (₹70) continues to delight diners. Decades after my first taste, it remains as memorable as ever. @YMCA Building, NSC Bose Road, Parry’s. A meal for two, ranges between ₹400 and ₹800.



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When I am planted next to a mammoth stainless-steel boiler of molten ghee, my mind starts playing games. The sweet smell is intoxicating. But the heat from the container which can hold 2,000 litres of ghee, that is at touching distance, sends me into a tizzy. For RKG Ghee’s workers in blue uniforms, who go about turning levers and adjusting the intricate system, the scent, heat, and vision of cloud-like tufts of butter transforming into grainy, sunshine-yellow ghee, are routine. For, this scene plays out every day at the 94-year-old family-run brand’s factory in Kangayam. The making of ghee here is a coordinated process that starts at its Atmos dairy in nearby Dharapuram. “We collect up to 1,50,000 litres of milk every day from 10,000 farmers in and around the town,” says G Aravind, the managing partner. The milk, once churned into butter, arrives as gigantic blocks to the factory in trucks. There are over 200 men and women working at the factory, which is spread across 80,000 sqft in the town that is 95 kilometres from Coimbatore. We go behind the scenes to see how ghee is made by the family-run establishment that supplies to states such



Smooth sailing

After nearly a century of making ghee, RKG is opening its doors to a ghee brewery, and a restaurant celebrating Kongu cuisine

as Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, apart from exporting to West Asia, New Zealand, Australia, Singapore, and the US. K Prakash, the plant manager, leads us inside the freezer where butter is stored at a temperature of -20°C. “We leave the blocks outside to thaw so that they reach ambient temperature before they are tipped into butter melting vats,” he explains. These vats send molten butter to the ghee boilers. “After around 20 minutes, the ghee is sent for settling,” he adds. This is a process where protein granules left behind after butter is clarified, settle at the bottom of the container. The ghee is not quite ready yet. Prakash says that to rid it entirely of the



brownish protein granules, it is further sent to a clarifier before which it is left to settle overnight. We follow its trail through pipes to tanks on a floor above, where it is left undisturbed for 48 hours to acquire its defining grainy texture. It is only now that it is ready. The ghee, produced over four days of precise monitoring, now enters an automated system of electronic devices and conveyors, to be packed

On a ghee trail Inside RKG’s factory in Kangayam near Coimbatore; (below) arisi paruppu sadham at their restaurant. S SIVA SARAVANAN



and sent to store shelves. Many years ago, 94 to be precise, RKG was a completely different entity. “As per our earliest records, the company was started in 1932,” says Aravind, adding that the founders – three men from the family – started selling ghee from the 1920s onwards. “They would gather butter from villages such as Padiyandipalayam, Veeranampalayam, and Madathupalayam through collection agents, to make ghee to be sold in tins,” he says. That was a time when mud pots and cold water kept butter from turning sour, and bullock carts transported the end product. Today, people such as 31-year-old KR Vikneswaran, who is from

the fourth generation in the family, are experimenting with offering something more than just one product. Vikneswaran, who has a love for cooking, is helming RKG Ghee Stories, an ‘experience centre’ at a complex on Karur Road near the factory. “Here, people can watch a scaled-down version of the processes that unfold at our factory,” he says, talking about the ‘ghee brewery’ where people can watch live butter being clarified. “They also get to buy fresh ghee,” he adds. The space has sweets and savouries and a restaurant with a fusion menu in which ghee is the star ingredient. We try the ghee mushroom cappuccino and the ghee Pallipalayam paneer. The soup comes with a drizzling of ghee on top, and is followed by arisi paruppu sadham, a Kongu staple that arrives with a side of nei kathirikkai. Rice, paruppu, and ghee: a match made in heaven. No, Kangayam.

Fresh off the loom

Meet master weavers and shop directly from the artisans at DakshinaChitra’s fundraiser

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For over two decades, Vastra Utsav has been a celebration of India’s rich textile heritage. Organised by the Friends of DakshinaChitra (FoD) as a fundraiser for DakshinaChitra, a living-history heritage museum on the ECR, the exhibition brings together master weavers, artisans, revivalists, and designers from across India. “This year, we are delighted to host Vastra Utsav at a large venue, with nearly 50 stalls. For the first time, visitors can also enjoy millet-based snacks from the southern states, alongside products from women self-help groups, including pickles, spice blends, and other homemade specialties. By bringing together artisans, weavers, and women entrepreneurs under one roof, Vastra Utsav continues to celebrate India’s cultural heritage

while supporting sustainable livelihoods,” says Srilakshmi Mohan Rao, president, FoD. Shantha Narayanan, committee member, FoD says that over two days, visitors can explore an extensive range of products, including saris, semi-stitched salwar sets, home furnishings, children’s wear, handicrafts, jewellery, and traditional food products. “Weavers from Rajasthan, West Bengal, Andhra Pradesh, Odisha, and Madhya Pradesh will showcase their finest creations. Many of the master weavers themselves will be present at their stalls, giving visitors the opportunity to appreciate the stories woven into every piece,” Shantha adds. The organisers say that there is also the satisfaction of supporting the diminishing breed of skilled artisans preserving Indian handloom. @Sri Kuchalambal Kalyana Mahal, Chetpet. On July 31 and August 1 from 10am to 8pm. Entry is free.



Take your pick A sneak peek at the exhibit. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT





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The Marina Beach in Chennai comes alive on weekends. Even as the smells of sundal and bajji waft through the air, eager children pester parents so they can ride a horse, or shoot balloons. Others prefer to silently gaze at the sea or the statues.

Not too far from the landmark Gandhi Statue at this beach stands another statue – except this one moves occasionally. Meet Nehemia Koche, who is now 68. He is a regular these days at the beach during weekend evenings, but he cannot afford to indulge in bajjis or games.

That is because Nehemia Koche is ‘Gandhi’. Using silver body paint, which he applies for about half an hour, Nehemia arrives at the Marina Beach every weekend and stands. He is mostly as still as a statue, but he does occasionally stretch his legs or salute the curious passers-by.

“People have forgotten Gandhiji. This is my way of reminding them about the father of the nation,” he says, taking a

# talks

## If you are at Chennai's Marina Beach on the weekends, chances are you have seen Nehemia Koche. Meet this street artiste who dresses up as Mahatma Gandhi

stroll after a tiring few hours of standing.

In that time, this street artiste has earned around 600 rupees. “It [the money I earn] depends on the number of people who visit the beach,” says Nehemia, who usually stands at the beach opposite the Public Works Department building, “Children love me and are usually excited to take pictures. Sometimes, they even want to touch me to see if I am real!” The adults, however, are more sober. “While some just

**The Marina Beach is my favourite. Even the policemen here treat me with respect. They sometimes give me food packets**

**NEHEMIA KOCHÉ**  
Street artiste

**Tales from the beach** Nehemia Koche dressed as Mahatma Gandhi at Marina Beach in Chennai. SRINIVASA RAMANUJAM

shake hands with me and go away, others are interested in selfies. A few of them donate some money in the box that I keep. Sometimes, they give me food too.”

Interestingly, Nehemia also has a QR code attached to his trousers, keeping with today’s times of digital transactions. “I have to find new ways of making ends meet. Back home, I have a 27-year-old daughter who wishes to start earning before she gets married. I am saving up for her future.”

**Play it up** Hailing from China Munagala village in Khammam district (Telangana), this street artiste has been performing and dressing up as the Mahatma for many years now. “Right from childhood, I have been interested in street theatre and plays. Whenever there was a festive occasion in our village, I would dress up as a character and attend the celebrations. I have also dressed up as lord Ram during temple festivities. Dressing up as a famous character has been a habit for me, especially during Sankaranthi and Ugadi,” he adds.

Over time, this act also started fetching him money, food and shelter. “I have travelled widely across India to popular tourist spots, especially the beaches of Mumbai and Vishakapatnam. The Marina Beach at Madras is one of my favourite places to come to – because people here are friendly. Even the policemen treat me with respect; they sometimes give me food packets.” Apart from beaches, he has also visited educational institutions in Warangal and Vishakapatnam dressed as Gandhi.

On August 15 this year, even as India celebrates its Independence Day, Nehemia will be back at his regular haunt on Marina Beach. As the beach comes alive with Independence Day celebrations, Gandhi will take a stroll.

# Camera obscura

A vintage camera shop at Moore Market shows us the best means to capture memories, the analog way

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In the middle of bustling Moore Market, A Rajan sits on his chair tapping a metal box beside him. Inside is a camera dating back to 1919. This is the oldest of his collection of vintage cameras, he says.

Rajan launched his outlet A Rajan Pazhaiya Camera Kadai in 2020. Although the COVID-19 pandemic led to a delay in attracting customers, Rajan quickly found his ground. He has been an entrepreneur since the day his father died in 2000, selling antiques and vintage finds from telephones to water bottles.

Eventually, he began focussing on cameras, establishing two separate shops at Moore Market. “I am crazy about cameras. I have also collected varieties of cameras and kept them at home,” says Rajan.

He has been learning about cameras and the era they belong to for 15 years. His collection of about 2,000 cameras, includes still cameras, polaroids, movie and instant cameras from brands such as Yashica, Minolta, Pentax, and Canon. While prices range from ₹1,500 to ₹2 lakh, customers often approach him to take the pieces on rent. Rajan insists that he loves all types of vintage cameras and has no favorite. He sources these cameras from dealers across the country, including from places like Coimbatore, Mumbai, and Kolkata. “Customers who have vintage cameras also sell them to me,” he says.

Rajan says he has also seen a passion for cameras in many of his customers. “I remember once a cameraperson, who had also sold some of his cameras to me, telling me that there was a time when he bought a Rolleiflex instead of land,” Rajan adds. Customers who visit the shop are often photographers and cinematographers looking for vintage



**Frozen in time** A Rajan’s collection of cameras now finds patrons in Gen Z. NEHA SASI

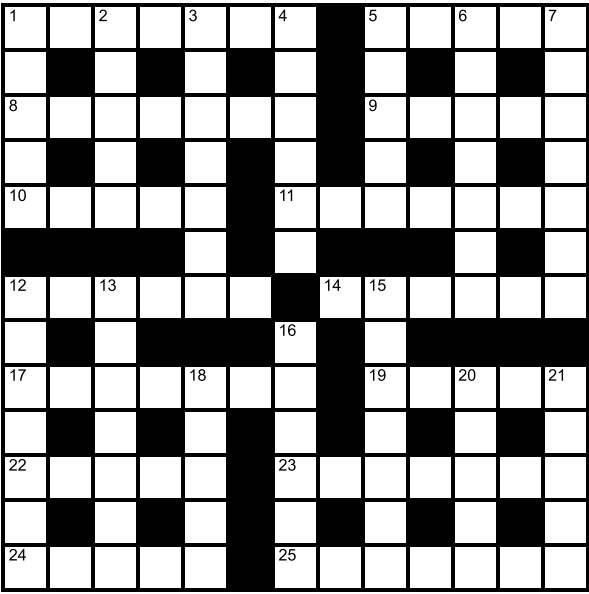
cameras to display in their studios, drawn by nostalgia. His cameras have also been used in films like *Madrasapattinam* and *Por Thozhil*.

College students, too, are increasingly buying them now, attracted by their trending retro aesthetic. Varun Gupta, founder, Chennai Photo Biennale Darkroom says that at a time when digital and AI-generated images dominate, their darkroom where they develop films, was created to be a learning space for analogue photographers. “People want to slow things and a way to disconnect with everything digital,” he says. While he agrees that buying films is an expensive affair, he also thinks it is worth the investment. There are people from all ages who are willing to work with analog cameras, he adds.

Today, Rajan is keen to expand his shop. “I want to bring more cameras that people have not seen before,” Rajan says.

A Rajan Pazhaiya Camera Kadai is at Lily Pond Complex, Moore Market. Contact 7358282833 for details.

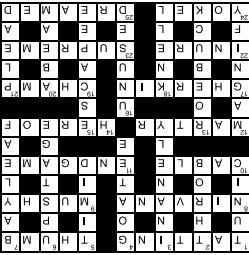
## METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #64 (Set by Doppelganger)



- Across**
- 1 Technique of making lace by hand (7)
  - 5 Thickest human digit (5)
  - 8 Buddhist state of mind (7)
  - 9 Soft and pulpy (5)
  - 10 Insulated conductor (5)
  - 11 Final stage in chess (7)
  - 12 One who suffers for their beliefs (6)
  - 14 Concerning this (6)
  - 17 Small cucumber (7)
  - 19 Chew noisily (5)
  - 22 Accept something difficult (5)
  - 23 Greatest in authority (7)
  - 24 Country bumpkin (5)
  - 25 Built castles in the air (7)
- Down**
- 1 Loose-fitting garment (5)
  - 2 Beat rapidly (5)
  - 3 In a way that is silly (7)
  - 4 Type of beard (6)
  - 5 Shy (5)
  - 6 Treat haughtily (7)
  - 7 Cooking seasoning (3,4)
  - 12 Enlarge (7)
  - 13 Male deer (7)
  - 15 Fugitive (7)
  - 16 Brand new (6)
  - 18 Ring slowly (5)
  - 20 At right angles to (5)
  - 21 Beg (5)



### Solution No. 64



## Heal the world

Katharoo Fest 2026 is a two-day storytelling festival for children. This year's theme is Our Earth, Our Responsibility. Children aged three to 10 can enjoy storytelling performances, DIY workshops, book exchanges, children's book stalls, and activities that involve upcycling waste fabrics. Young storytellers will also have the opportunity to take the stage.

@Sir Sivaswami Kalalaya Senior Secondary School, Mylapore on August 1 and 2, from 10am to 5pm. Tickets are priced at ₹500 for one child and one parent, and ₹1,000 for two children and two parents. Workshop fee is ₹500 per participant. To register, call 9841013108.



**Old Bollywood magic** Relive the music of Kishore Kumar at Satrangi Music's Kaptivating Kishore, featuring Promod Nair and Smriti Banerjee singing solos and duets from the 1950s to the 1980s on pre-recorded tracks. The concert will be held on August 9, at 5.30pm at Teach Auditorium, Taramani. Tickets are priced at ₹500 and ₹300 and can be home-delivered by contacting Promod at 9884778073.



## Run the world

After a seven-year hiatus, Zydus Pinkathon returns to Chennai on August 1 and 2 at Island Grounds showcasing stories of resilience and determination. The event features race categories from 3km to ultra runs of 100km from 11am to 7pm. For more details on the race, visit pinkathon.life.

SATHYAM | ESCAPE | INOX CITY CENTRE | DEVI CINEPLEX | PVR AMPA MALL | SANGAM | EGA | KAMALA | PALAZZO | PVR VR MALL | PVR LUXE VELACHERY | PVR GRAND MALL VELACHERY | AGS OMR | CINEPOLIS OMR | INOX MARINA MALL | PVR ECR | PVR AEROHUB | PVR REDHILLS | PVR PALLAVARAM | INOX NATIONAL | AGS T NAGAR | AGS MADURAVOYAL | AGS VILLIVAKKAM | S2 PERAMBUR | GK PORUR | RAKKI & MURUGAN AMBATTUR | KASI ASHOK NAGAR | MAYAJAAL | ROHINI KOYAMBEDU | VETRI CHROMPET | VIJAY PARK GANGA KOLATHUR | SIVASAKTHI PADI | GREEN CINEMAS PADI | LATHA CHENGALPATTU | MK CINEMAS SRIPERUMBUDUR | VARADHARAJA CHITLAPAKKAM | VIDHYA TAMBARAM | ODEON MANI TIRUVOTTIYUR | RAKKI CINEMAS THIRUVALLUR | MVR GUDUVANCHERY

ஸ்பைடர்-மேன்  
BRAND NEW DAY

SPIDER-MAN  
BRAND NEW DAY

IN CINEMAS TODAY

IN ENGLISH, HINDI, TAMIL, TELUGU, MALAYALAM & KANNADA

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COLUMBIA TRISTAR

CM YK 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 A





# Cop mode on

Malayalam actor Kunchacko Boban on why his *Unmadham* character is unlike any other he has played before

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It is hard to believe that next year, 2027, Kunchacko Boban, affectionately called Chackochan, will complete 30 years in the film industry. Ageless, as an adjective, does not convey it. He is all smiles as he settles down for the conversation about his latest film, *Unmadham*, his years in the industry, and being seen as an actor rather than a star. *Unmadham* will be Kunchacko Boban's third film with writer Shahi Kabir, best known for writing cop stories drawn from his own experience as a policeman. Three cop roles with the same writer? This is from an actor who did not want to be stereotyped. Chackochan anticipates the question. "It is a cop role, but all the police characters I have essayed in Shahi's movies, be it Praveen



Michael of *Nayattu* or Hari Sankar of *Officer on Duty*, are different. Shelly (in *Unmadham*) cannot be connected to the other two or even the movies. During the trailer launch event, he (Shahi) announced that this movie doesn't have the typical, dark ending of a Shahi Kabir movie! This is the first Shahi Kabir movie with the U 13+ censor certificate."

A 'surprise' element of the film is the combination of a regular police station story/thriller with a dash of the supernatural, which, he feels, would work with the audience.

Shelly is a police constable who wants to be in films, like Shahi. "Naturally, the characters and episodes in the film have shades of real life and resemble Shahi's experiences but are told more cinematically."

The other factor Chackochan is convinced would work for the film is the cast, which boasts names like Lijomol Jose and Sudheesh.

He makes special mention of the director, Kiran Das, a debutant who brings the experience of having edited films like *Thondimuthalum Driksakshiyum*, *Joseph*, *Moothon*, *Joji*, *Ela Veezha* *Poonchira*,

**The problem with hyped movies is the expectations, which, fortunately, Unmadham doesn't have. We feel it is a blessing in disguise!**

KUNCHACKO BOBAN  
Actor

**Shades of khaki** Kunchacko Boban (left); and a still from *Unmadham*. THULASI KAKKAT

*Romancham*, and *Ullozhukku*, among others. It was Shahi who suggested working with Kiran, and Chackochan was only too happy to do so – because Kiran was a newcomer, which meant less pressure, not too much hype. "The problem with hyped movies is the expectations, which fortunately *Unmadham* doesn't have. We feel it is a blessing in disguise!"

**Donning khaki, again** Three cop characters imagined and written by the same writer – how different was the process of getting into character?

"Pravin from *Nayattu* was hunted by the system, which sidelined him and made him sceptical about whether he should fight or surrender to it. In *Officer on Duty*, Hari Sankar is strong-headed and arrogant. So I had these two examples telling me what not to do with Shelly. His own thoughts drive him and he follows his fantasies."

The actor's characters, of late, have been more varied; there is no hesitation when it comes to the length of the role, whether the story pivoted his character, was part of an ensemble cast, or was a 'female-oriented' film. He has been driven by a desire to avoid being typecast. Chackochan once said he envied his peers – Prithviraj, Jayasurya and Indrajith – who were able to avoid the trap.

"That envy helped me try different things, new things. I had my share of ups and downs, but those made me stronger. My contemporaries ignited my passion, showing me the way. I am thankful for that; after all, competition makes you better."

When asked the best things about his three decades in the industry, Chackochan says, "Movies may make or break you, but you have to get up again and move forward. When I came back to movies after a break, I made it a point that I didn't play the hero. I started small – cameos, guest appearances, special roles, female-oriented films. I ensured I was part of all memorable movies in Malayalam. I took small steps forward. Then opinions changed, and the audience accepted me as an actor, not as a star. This was my priority. I worked hard for it. So, when people say that my last 15-odd movies show a drastic change in my acting, it is something I hoped and wished for. And that makes me more responsible about what I do going forward."

*Unmadham is set to release in theatres on July 31*

## Becoming Nivi

Fresh off the success of *Chennai Love Story*, Sri Gouri Priya reflects on her choice of Telugu and Tamil films

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Entering a packed cinema hall of around 800 people, listening to them cheer and call me by my character name has been both humbling and a validation of my choices," says actor Sri Gouri Priya, taking in the appreciation for her Telugu film *Chennai Love Story*, which released on July 24.

In director Ravi Namburii's film, written and produced by Sai Rajesh, Gouri plays Nivedita aka Nivi, a woman who finds refuge in alcohol after being ghosted on her wedding day. The love story that blooms eventually also takes unexpected turns with emotional upheavals.

Gouri agreed to do the film the very day the story was narrated to her, and began preparing soon after. "I am inquisitive. Beyond what's in the script, I spoke to the director and Sai Rajesh *garu* to understand Nivedita's psyche." She was keen to know the character's strengths and vulnerabilities so she could develop her body language and tone of speech. "All this helped the performance fall in place." Gouri also pitched in with her perspectives on how the character is likely to react to situations.

The recognition Gouri is getting for *Chennai Love Story* can also be looked at as a major

turning point in her career. Ever since she debuted in Telugu with *Mail: Kambalapalli Kathalu*, she has mostly chosen characters that have a voice.

In Tamil, Gouri was approached for the *Modern Love Chennai* anthology (for the story *Lalagunda Bommaigal* directed by Raju Murugan) and the film *Lover*. Language was an area of concern but Gouri worked on it. "I had grown up speaking Telugu, English and some Hindi. The North Madras Tamil my character spoke in *MLC* was different from the way Tamil was spoken on set. I picked up the language gradually; I can now speak and read Tamil and also listen to story narrations in the language. To date, people send me reels about my character in *Lover* and ask me why I left Arun (Manikandan's character). That's how much they like my work and I understood the enduring power of cinema."

Moving forward, she is keen to explore varied genres. "I am aware that some people call me *azhmoonji* (cry baby) in Tamil. I want to explore humour, fantasy and drama, which is why I agreed to act in *Happy Raj*."

That said, she is acutely aware of film industries being largely hero-centric. "I am not in a rush to do a number of films within a short time. I want to be seen, but I am conscious of how I want to be seen. I'd rather be recognised as a performer."

**Balancing act** Kiran Abbavaram and Sri Gouri Priya in the film. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



## Finding hope through music

Sheetal Menon opens up on directing *Duet*, which holds the distinction of becoming Spotify's first-ever short film release



**A lonely melody** Sidhant Gupta (left) with Sheetal on the sets of *Duet*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Deepali Dhingra

A few years ago, Sheetal Menon was on the verge of walking away from the entertainment industry. After years as a successful model and actor, the agonising wait for good work had left her questioning if there was anything left for her in cinema. She didn't expect that stepping into an acting and creative workshop to figure out her next move would lead her behind the camera instead.

A story handed to her by her filmmaker husband Bejoy Nambiar for an improvisation session prompted her to develop it into a screenplay. "I didn't even know how to write one!" she recalls. "I would sit in a coffee shop every day and just will myself to do it. I also met my co-writer Arpita Chatterjee during this journey, and the two of us just clicked," she says.

A year later, that quiet persistence gave birth to her 2019 directorial debut, *Sibling*, and now, her sophomore short film, *Duet*. A poignant meditation on grief, music, and the unspoken connections that pull us out of despair, *Duet* marks a major industry shift. Starring Sidhant Gupta of *Jubilee* fame and backed by Bejoy, it is the first short film ever to be released on Spotify and will also be available to stream on Getaway Pictures' YouTube channel.

The short film follows a grieving pianist grappling with the sudden loss of his

estranged brother amid the isolation of the pandemic. As he plays through his grief, an inexplicable, distant violin responds to his tune, creating a haunting, unspoken musical dialogue that pulls him back toward hope.

Although the plot is not autobiographical, its emotional centre is formed by a deeply shared collective reality. "During

the pandemic, some of us were asking ourselves what was happening to people suffering alone in their homes," Sheetal explains. When she shared a draft of her story with a renowned musician, he broke down on the phone, telling her he had gone through similar moments of despair.

"That was my moment of reassurance that the story was

touching something real," she says.

The pre-production took a major chunk of time. Sidhant had never played a musical instrument in his life, and it took a few sessions of coaching and practising on his rental piano for him to feel ready to take on this role. The film's evocative music is at the heart of the narrative, and it took

Sheetal almost a year to find her music collaborators. She had a reference playlist on Spotify featuring global pianist-composers such as Eric Christian from New York, Ben Crosland from London, and Sydney-based Sid Acharya. Taking a long shot, she messaged them on Instagram. To her astonishment, all three replied, stating they resonated with the pandemic-centric narrative. While Ben and Eric gave her permission to use their existing original works, Sid composed the background score. "Finding the music, for me, was the most beautiful part of making this film," she smiles.

But the struggle was not over. The completed film sat in Sheetal's hard drive for almost three years, without finding a distribution outlet. "I had completely given up at one point," she candidly admits, adding that although short films take the same effort and money as larger formats, there is no proper ecosystem to release them. The turning point came when Bejoy and their mutual friend and producer Harini Lakshminarayan suggested pitching the music-heavy film to Spotify, and the platform responded immediately, scheduling the film to release on July 30.

With *Duet* now finding its audience, Sheetal is ready to take on a full-length feature and has a story ready, too. For a filmmaker who questioned if there was anything left for her in cinema, it looks like Sheetal has just started her journey.



**Vadhandhi Season 2 gets a release date**

*Vadhandhi* Season 2 — *The Mystery of Mani*, the second season of Prime Video's Tamil original suspense thriller series, will premiere on the platform on August 7. The show is created, written, and directed by Andrew Louis.

Produced under the banner of Wallwatcher Films by Pushkar and Gayatri, the eight-episode series stars M Sasikumar in the lead, alongside Yashwanth, Anagha Maruthora, Aparna Das, Vivek Prasanna, Revathy Sharma, and Arjun Nandhakumar.



**Naslen to headline *Kumbalangi Nights* director's next**

Malayalam star Naslen will headline filmmaker Madhu C Narayanan's upcoming film. The project marks Madhu's return to direction after a hiatus following his celebrated directorial debut, *Kumbalangi Nights*, which was released in 2019.

The project will be produced by Dr Ananthu and Madhu, under the banners of Dr Ananthu Productions and Silent Cat Films.

Naslen was last seen in *Mollywood Times*, directed by Abhinav Sunder Nayak.